



A VENDOR sells snacks to truck drivers waiting to cross the border in Tijuana. Experts say American consumers may find higher prices for fresh vegetables, fruits and other perishable imports in a matter of days.

COUNCIL WILL NOT REINSTATE CROWLEY

The 13-2 vote against former L.A. fire chief gives Mayor Bass a much-needed boost.

BY DAVID ZAHNISER,
JULIA WICK
AND DAKOTA SMITH

The Los Angeles City Council rejected former Fire Chief Kristin Crowley's bid to get her job back, despite fierce support for her from the firefighters' union.

The council voted 13 to 2 on Tuesday against Crowley's reinstatement, handing embattled Mayor Karen Bass a much-needed political victory. Bass was in Ghana when the Palisades fire broke out, leaving council President Marqueece Harris-Dawson as acting mayor, and delivered a choppy performance in the days after she returned.

Crowley used Tuesday's hearing to push back publicly, for the first time, against the arguments that Bass offered for terminating her from her post as the head of one of the nation's largest fire departments. Seated before the council, Crowley argued that she was

[See **Ex-fire chief**, A12]



FORMER L.A. Fire Chief Kristin Crowley gets a hug from a firefighter after the vote on Tuesday. Crowley said she should not be punished for speaking honestly.

Bass' aides were warned of fire danger before trip

An emergency official emailed the mayor's team a forecast for 'damaging winds.'

BY DAKOTA SMITH
AND DAVID ZAHNISER

The day before Los Angeles Mayor Karen Bass left for Ghana, her aides received an email from the city's Emergency Management Department warning of a

"high confidence in damaging winds and elevated fire conditions occurring next week."

The mayor nevertheless went on the trip, attending the Ghanaian president's inauguration, as well as a U.S. Embassy cocktail party, on Jan. 7, the day the Palisades fire broke out.

Bass' team did not inform her of the Friday, Jan. 3, email, which advised of a meeting the following Monday to coordinate preparations for the anticipated

high winds. In the days before Bass' flight, the National Weather Service had also begun alerting the public on social media about the growing wildfire risk.

Bass, over the last few weeks, has accused former Fire Chief Kristin Crowley of failing to warn her of the potential for a cataclysmic wind event. She told Fox II she would not even have traveled as far as San Diego had she been informed of the fire danger.

[See **Warnings**, A9]

Trump tariffs end decades of free trade in North America

The sweeping taxes threaten the intricate U.S.-Mexico-Canada commercial colossus.

BY KATE LINTHICUM AND
PATRICK J. McDONNELL

MEXICO CITY — Sweeping tariffs imposed Tuesday by President Trump are sending shock waves through global supply chains, roiling markets and shaking the very foundations of the more than three-decade free trade regimen that made Mexico, Canada and the United States a unified commercial colossus.

Beginning with the North American Free Trade Agreement in 1994, the three-nation bloc embraced the principle that duty-free commerce was a winning strategy and a hedge against competition from Asia, Europe and elsewhere — an assumption that now seems very much under threat.

As of Tuesday, Washington began levying a 25% tax on all products imported from Mexico and Canada, with the exception of Canadian oil and gas, which are subject to a 10% tariff. Trump also imposed a new 10% tax on imports from China.

Canada and China swiftly announced retaliatory taxes on U.S. goods, and Mexico said it would soon announce its own counter-tariffs.

Canadian Prime Minister Justin Trudeau, describing a plan to start taxing more than \$100 billion of American goods over the course of three weeks, said Trump's economic attack on Canada

[See **Tariffs**, A4]

Get ready for pricier avocados

Tariffs will also hit Mexican tequila and beer — items popular in California. **BUSINESS**, A8

Probation officers indicted in fights

The 30 L.A. County overseers are accused of child endangerment in allowing brawls.

BY JAMES QUEALLY
AND REBECCA ELLIS

Thirty officers from the Los Angeles County Probation Department have been indicted on criminal charges after an investigation into allegations they allowed — and in some cases encouraged — fights between teens inside the county's juvenile halls.

An indictment unsealed late Monday afternoon contains 71 counts of child abuse, conspiracy and battery against 30 probation officers, alleging their involvement in a series of fights that took place from July to December 2023. Two officers — Taneha Brooks and Shawn Smyles — are accused of telling other officers not to intervene or make reports

when fights happened, according to the indictment.

Smyles told youths involved in fights not to seek medical attention, in order to cover up the brawls, the indictment said. Late Monday, California Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta referred to the coordinated brawls as "gladiator fights."

The indictments were the result of a California Department of Justice investigation launched after state investigators were leaked security video — published last year by The Times — that shows eight probation officers standing idly by while a group of teens attacked a 17-year-old inside Los Padrinos Juvenile Hall in Downey. The teen suffered a broken nose and a "traumatic brain injury," according to a civil claim filed last year. Details of the indictments were first reported by The Times last month.

"The officers look more like referees or audience members at a prizefight, not

[See **Fights**, A12]

Trump's address to Congress

Visit latimes.com for coverage of president's speech to a joint session of both chambers.

Newsom orders return to office

Mandate of four days a week is decreed by labor union and legal group. **CALIFORNIA**, B1

Oscars draw in more viewers

The number tuning in to Academy Awards rises slightly to 19.7 million. **BUSINESS**, A8

Weather

Rain; cooler.
L.A. Basin: 60/48. **B6**

For the latest news, go to latimes.com.



Federal cuts hit water agency staff in state

Musk team slashes 10% of the U.S. Bureau of Reclamation's regional workers.

BY IAN JAMES

The Trump administration has ordered firings and buyouts at the federal agency that operates water infrastructure in California, potentially jeopardizing the agency's ability to manage dams and deliver water, according to Central Valley water officials.

The job cuts at the Bureau of Reclamation were ordered by Elon Musk's so-called Department of Government Efficiency, or DOGE, according to two bureau employees who were not authorized to speak publicly.

The bureau, which employs about 1,000 people, is set to lose about 100 employees in California through terminations and buyouts, eliminating about 10% of its regional staff, one of the employees said. But larger workforce reductions are planned, and the bureau has been ordered to prepare plans to cut its staff by 40%, this person said.

Those targeted first for dismissal have been employees in their first year and others who have been at the agency the shortest.

The Trump administration has offered millions of government workers eight months of salary if they voluntarily agree to leave.

The employees who have applied for "deferred resignation" buyouts include Karl Stock, the bureau's regional director for the California

[See **Water**, A7]



THE FRIANT DAM, completed in 1942 and operated by the U.S. Bureau of Reclamation, relies on employees for increasingly frequent repairs and inspections.



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